

BAD IDEAS ABOUT WRITING

Edited by Cheryl E. Ball & Drew M. Loewe



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West Virginia University Libraries
Digital Publishing Institute
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INTRODUCTION

Cheryl E. Ball and Drew M. Loewe

Beginning in 1998, Edge.org has asked a diverse group of scholars, intellectuals, and artists the annual Edge Question, a question designed to spark arguments about provocative ideas to be published online and collected into print volumes intended for a general public audience. Edge Questions have included such questions as “What is your dangerous idea?,” “What have you changed your mind about? Why?,” and the one that inspired this collection: “What scientific idea is ready for retirement?” That last question was the 2014 Edge Question, published in a book titled *This Idea Must Die: Scientific Theories that are Blocking Progress*. Drew first saw the book in a publisher’s exhibit at the 2015 Conference on College Composition and Communication, a big annual convention of writing teachers and scholars. After reading the book, especially in the context of an academic convention, Drew suggested on social media that the field of writing studies should publish its own collective effort to name particularly unhelpful or backward ideas and argue directly to the public about them. Cheryl replied right away that she would be on board, and thus this project was born.

This project is necessary because while scholars in writing studies (just as in any academic field) argue to and against one another in scholarly journals, books, and conference talks, those forms of knowledge-making don’t consistently find their way into the public’s understanding of writing. Yet “the public” in all its manifestations—teachers, students, parents, administrators, lawmakers, news media—are important to how writing is conceptualized and taught. These publics deserve clearly articulated and well-researched arguments about what is not working, what must die, and what is blocking progress in current understandings of writing. So our call for proposals sought contributions that provided a snapshot

of major myths about writing instruction—written by experts for the educated public—that could collectively spark debate and have us rethink our pieties and myths. This collection is an attempt by a varied and diverse group of writing scholar-teachers to translate our specialized knowledge and experiences about writing for a truly wide set of audiences, most of whom will never read the scholarly journals and books or attend conferences about this topic because of the closed nature of such publications and proceedings. In keeping with the public purpose of these writings, it was important to us that it be published open-access. Because there are so few options for trade-like academic books that are open access, we decided—in consultation with the authors of this collection—to publish *Bad Ideas About Writing* as an open educational resource through the Digital Publishing Institute, which Cheryl directs. *Bad Ideas* will join other books in West Virginia University Library’s nascent digital publishing project, where it will be supported by librarians for a long time to come.

We intend this work to be less a bestiary of bad ideas about writing than an effort to name bad ideas and suggest better ones. Some of those bad ideas are quite old, such as the archetype of the inspired genius author, the five-paragraph essay, or the abuse of adjunct writing teachers. Others are much newer, such as computerized essay scoring or gamification. Some ideas, such as the supposed demise of literacy brought on by texting, are newer bad ideas but are really instances of older bad ideas about literacy always being in a cycle of decline. Yet the same core questions such as *what is good writing*, *what makes a good writer*, *how should writing be assessed*, and the like persist across contexts, technologies, and eras. The project has its genesis in frustration, but what emerges is hope: hope for leaving aside bad ideas and thinking about writing in more productive, inclusive, and useful ways.

The individual entries, which we came to dub as both opinionated encyclopedia entries and researched mini-manifestos, offer syntheses of relevant research and experience along with cross-references to other entries that take up related subjects. Instead of the typical trappings of academic citation styles (APA, MLA, Chicago, Oxford, etc.) that are specific to certain disciplines, we asked authors in the *Bad Ideas* collection to summarize the available research and present it in a way similar to how a newspaper, introductory textbook, or podcast might deliver such research—not through individual citations, but through a list of resources and further reading that would point readers to follow-up material.

The authors of these entries are often published experts in these fields, so searching for their other work at a library or online will produce additional information on these topics. We have provided keywords for each entry as well, which correspond to the academic terms that would appear in other peer-reviewed, published research on these topics.

The entries cohere around eight major categories of bad ideas about writing that are tied to the production, circulation, cultural use of, evaluation, and teaching of writing in multiple ways. The categories are bad ideas about:

- The features of good writing
- What makes good writers
- How grammar and style should be understood
- Which techniques or processes produce good writing
- Particular genres and occasions for writing
- How writing should be assessed
- How technology impacts writing
- Teachers of writing

Although we have categories (and there are thematic clusters visible within the larger categories), we encourage readers to read the entries with and against each other, looking for productive overlaps and disagreements. For instance, there are at least three entries on the five-paragraph essay—the genre perhaps most known by the various publics reading this book, and the most maligned by its writers—and each entry takes a different perspective, disagreeing as needed where the research and the writer’s experience pertain.

Without forcing a weak consensus or flattening out the individuality of the chapters, together they offer a practical, action-oriented group of rational manifestos for discontinuing unhelpful or exclusionary ideas about a subject and activity that all have a stake in. We hope that the collection is a conversation-starter, not a conversation-stopper, and we hope that it provides a catalog of support for productive conversations about how and why to stop the bad ideas about writing and start the good.

EDITOR BIOS AND ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Cheryl E. Ball is associate professor of digital publishing studies in the Professional Writing and Editing program at West Virginia University. She is also editor of *Kairos: A Journal of Rhetoric, Technology, and Pedagogy* as well as the #writing book series with the WAC Clearinghouse/Colorado State University Open Press, both of which are open-access publishing venues available to anyone with an Internet connection. She teaches the importance of editing content in a digital world, and offers a special thank you to all of the undergraduate and graduate students at WVU who helped with the publication of this book. She also thanks WVU Libraries for its support of the Digital Publishing Institute. Finally, she is grateful to Drew M. Loewe for coming up with the idea for this book and for agreeing to let her work on it with him.

Drew M. Loewe is an associate professor of writing and rhetoric at St. Edward's University in Austin, Texas, where he also directs the Writing Center. His scholarly and teaching interests include rhetorical theory and criticism, argumentation, prose style, legal writing, writing centers, research methods, and the first-year writing sequence. He thanks St. Edward's for supporting this project with time and money, and especially thanks Cheryl E. Ball for being the best co-editor anyone could hope for.

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Bad Ideas About Writing counters major myths about writing instruction. Inspired by the provocative science- and social-science-focused book *This Idea Must Die* and written for a general audience, the collection offers opinionated, research-based statements intended to spark debate and to offer a better way of teaching writing. Contributors, as scholars of rhetoric and composition, provide a snapshot of and antidotes to major myths in writing instruction.

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“Bad Ideas About Writing offers its readers a wealth of good ideas for countering the dangerous myths, harmful stereotypes, unfounded folklore, romantic delusions, and fanciful thinking that too often surround questions about how best to improve written expression. It features recommendations for achievable goals from an incredible variety of top scholars and models good writing practices itself in its contributors’ insightful, accessible prose.

Students, policy makers, parents, and instructors will all benefit from its constructive criticism, which is made available to the public online in an open-access format. For those tired of moral panics that Johnny can’t write, this book is a readable and refreshing correction to hyperbole and humorlessness and provides a great replacement for the just-so stories and dreary textbooks that currently fill too many shelves on the topic of rhetoric and composition.”

Elizabeth Losh, author of *The War on Learning*, *Virtualpolitik*, and co-author of *Understanding Rhetoric*.

Cheryl E. Ball is Associate Professor of Digital Publishing Studies at West Virginia University.

Drew M. Loewe is an Associate Professor of Writing and Rhetoric at St. Edward’s University, where he also directs the Writing Center.



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